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Faith and Love

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Faith and Love

Romans 4:13–5:8

I accepted Christ by faith as a 16-year-old. I believed that Jesus was the Son of God who died for my sins and I invited Him into my life. From that moment on I knew that I would go to heaven; eternal life is God's free gift to all who believe.

Yet tragically, although I knew by faith that Jesus was God's Son, I did not understand the scope of His unconditional love for me. And because I didn't really understand God's love, I totally missed seeing God's plan for humanity. But God is love and love is at the center of His plan for all His creation. Over time I have learned that God's love is the foundation for understanding the entire Bible—including, of course, this passage from Romans.

In the beginning, Adam knew only a loving union with God. But when Adam sinned and ate from the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Evil, union with God was broken and his whole nature and way of life changed. Rather than living in unity with a loving Father and relying on His leading, humans now had to make their own independent way in life—based on their knowledge of good and evil.

This grieved God. His most treasured of all creation was severed from His loving relationship. And so, God planned a total and complete rescue. It would cost Him dearly, but He would pay any price ... because He loved us and the creation over which we were designed to rule.

To begin the process of restoration, God gave Moses the Ten Commandments. These commands, together with the other Old Covenant laws, gave clarity to what was good and what was evil. However, humans couldn't obey the rules. The Old Covenant law identified what was good and evil, but it did not come with the ability to obey what it demanded. In this way the law both defined sin and made us all sinners by virtue of our disobedience.

But in God's plan, the insufficiency of the law pointed us to the sufficiency of Christ. Even while we were sinners trapped under the bondage of the law, God reached down and loved us. Through Jesus' sacrificial death, He paid the price for our separation and sin.

As Paul clearly tells us in the following passage, God promised Abraham a right standing with Him that comes by faith. Through faith in Jesus Christ, God provided a way for us to be reconciled to Himself. Then in restored union with God, He continually pours His limitless love into our hearts.

Read Romans 4:13-5:8

Chapter 4

13It was not through the law that Abraham and his offspring received the promise that he would be heir of the world, but through the righteousness that comes by faith. 14For if those who depend on the law are heirs, faith means nothing and the promise is worthless, 15because the law brings wrath. And where there is no law there is no transgression.

16Therefore, the promise comes by faith, so that it may be by grace and may be guaranteed to all Abraham's offspring—not only to those who are of the law but also to those who have the faith of Abraham. He is the father of us all. 17As it is written: 'I have made you a father of many nations.' He is our father in the sight of God, in whom he believed—the God who gives life to the dead and calls into being things that were not.

18Against all hope, Abraham in hope believed and so became the father of many nations, just as it had been said to him, 'So shall your offspring be.' 19Without weakening in his faith, he faced the fact that his body was as good as dead—since he was about a hundred years old—and that Sarah's womb was also dead. 20Yet he did not waver through unbelief regarding the promise of God, but was strengthened in his faith and gave glory to God, 21being fully persuaded that God had power to do what he had promised. 22This is why 'it was credited to him as righteousness.' 23The words 'it was credited to him' were written not for him alone, 24but also for us, to whom God will credit righteousness—for us who believe in him who raised Jesus our Lord from the dead. 25He was delivered over to death for our sins and was raised to life for our justification.

Chapter 5

1Therefore, since we have been justified through faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ, 2through whom we have gained access by faith into this grace in which we now stand. And we boast in the hope of the glory of God. 3Not only so, but we also glory in our sufferings, because we know that suffering produces perseverance; 4perseverance, character; and character, hope. 5And hope does not put us to shame, because God's love has been poured out into our hearts through the Holy Spirit, who has been given to us.

6You see, at just the right time, when we were still powerless, Christ died for the ungodly. 7Very rarely will anyone die for a righteous person, though for a good person someone might possibly dare to die. 8But God demonstrates his own love for us in this: while we were still sinners, Christ died for us.

Questions

1. In your own words, what are verses 4:13-16 saying?
2. According to verses 4:18-21, how did Abraham respond to God's promise that he would be "heir of the world" (v. 13) and the "father of many nations" (v. 17)?
3. Abraham's faith was tested. Recall and describe a test of faith you have experienced in your life.
4. In what specific ways might God be challenging you personally to live by faith?
5. According to verses 5:1-5, what are some of the things of God we have access to by faith?
6. In verse 5:2, Paul says that by faith we have "access" into God's grace and we "stand" in that grace. Compare what it means to have "access" into grace versus what it means to "stand" in grace. How do you have "access"? In what ways are you "standing"?
7. Imagine "boast[ing] in the hope of the glory of God" (see verse 5:2). The New King James Version uses the word "rejoice[ing]." What feelings and images do these words bring to mind?
8. How might verses 5:3-5 encourage you in times of suffering or tribulation?
9. Recall and describe a time when trials in your life, or the life of another you know, resulted in godly character changes.
0. According to verse 5:5, how does the love of God get into our hearts?
1. The Old Covenant law says, "Love the Lord your God with all your heart with all your soul and with all your mind" (Matthew 22:37). How does God's love, as shown in verses 5:5 and 8, differ from that spoken of in the law?
2. See verses 5:5 and 8 as promises of God's love to you. How might you personally "stand" in (not just have "access to") those promises? (Consider how Abraham stood in the promises God gave to him.)

Reflection

Quiet your racing mind. Read verses 5:5-8 again.

Imagine God demonstrating His love toward you. The Holy Spirit is pouring, pouring, pouring love into your heart. See a stream of living water flooding into you. Its source is the pure, never-ending love of God. See yourself accepting that love. Drink it in. Rest in it. Grow in it. Let it become part of you and flow out of you to others.